

MAINS MASTER PROGRAM (MMP) 2024

International Relations-4

Regional Groupings, United Nations

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West Asia

Recent Changes in the region

- In response to Hamas' overnight attack on Israel, Israel launched attack on Gaza resulting in death and destruction in Gaza. There have also been fire exchanges Israel with Hezbollah, Houthis and Iran.
- Saudi has opened its airspace for Israeli civilian aircrafts and has permitted direct flights from Israel for Hajj pilgrims.
- Saudi has also agreed to normalise its relations with Israel. In exchange for opening formal ties with Israel, the Saudis have asked the United States for security guarantees, help developing a civilian nuclear program and fewer restrictions on US arms sales.
- In March 2023, Iran and Saudi Arabia agreed to re-establish relations after years of hostility.
- Turkey has also made overtures to Saudi Arabia. Besides accepting the Saudi court verdict on the Khashoggi murder case, Turkey has indicated it could work with the Saudis against the Houthis and facilitate the post-war political process.

In the West Asia, there are three key powers. Saudi Arabia, Iran and Israel. The push and pull between these three and their mutually contradictory world views has kept West Asia unstable and a geopolitical hotspot.

Significance of West Asia:

1. The Middle East accounts for 31% of global oil production, 18% of gas production, 48% of proved oil reserves and 40% of proved gas reserves.
2. Land bridge to Asia, Europe and Africa.
3. It has important centres of religions like Islam, Judaism and Christianity.
4. Geopolitical playground for global powers.
5. Key Sea Lanes of Communication and choke points.
6. Centre of global instability due to terrorism, factional wars, migrant crisis and nuclear aspirations.

Important Information:

1. Saudi Arabia is a monarchy while both Iran and Israel are democracies.
2. Saudi Arabia is the leader of Sunni world, Iran is a Shia nation while Israel is Jewish and has conflict with the Palestinian people.
3. Both Israel and Saudi Arabia are allies of USA while Iran has conflict with USA and is in Russia's camp.
4. Israel is a nuclear power and a technology leader; Saudi Arabia is an energy leader while Iran energy exports have been restricted by U.S. sanctions.
5. Iran's support to the militias in the region like Hezbollah in Lebanon and Houthi rebels in Yemen directly goes against the interests of Saudi Arabia and Israel.
6. Saudi Arabia looks at Iran's democracy and Muslim Brotherhood as a threat to its monarchy.

7. However, in recent times there have been shift in the geopolitics of the region. UAE, a close partner of Saudi Arabia has gone along with Israel to form I2U2. Saudi Arabia is also in talks with Iran and it has rejected the USA calls for increasing oil production in the wake of high crude prices due to Ukraine war and subsequent sanctions on Russia. Both Israel and Saudi Arabia are part of IMEC Corridor.

Gulf Cooperation Council:

1. A Constitution was initiated in March 1981 and was signed by the Gulf Heads of State (Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE) on May 25-26, 1981 at Abu Dhabi, the UAE. Consequently, the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) came into existence.
2. The GCC is a political and economic alliance of countries in the Arabian Peninsula.
3. All current member states are monarchies, including three constitutional monarchies (Qatar, Kuwait, and Bahrain), two absolute monarchies (Saudi Arabia and Oman), and one federal monarchy (the United Arab Emirates).
4. During the Arab Spring in 2011, Saudi Arabia raised a proposal to transform the GCC into a "Gulf Union" with tighter economic, political and military coordination, regarded as a move to counterbalance the Iranian influence in the region.

Peninsula Shield Force

- The Peninsula Shield Force (Peninsula Shield) is the military arm of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC).
- It is intended to deter, and respond to, military aggression against any of the GCC member countries: Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, and the United Arab Emirates.

ISRAEL

Significance of Israel:

1. Most important USA partner in West Asia.
2. Only democracy in the region.
3. A de-facto nuclear power.
4. A key partner in fight against terrorism.
5. A reliable partner in exporting state of the art defence platforms, platform upgradations during critical times.
6. Technology leader in defence manufacturing, UAVs, Agriculture, precision farming etc.

India-Israel Relations

India announced its recognition of Israel in 1950 itself, however, embassies were opened in 1992 when full diplomatic relations were established.

PM Modi undertook an historic first ever visit by an Indian PM to Israel in July 2017, during which the relationship was upgraded to a 'strategic' level. India also dehyphenated its Israel-Palestine relationship.

Defence & Security:

- India is Israel's largest buyer of military hardware.
- SIPRI Report for 2013-17: Israel accounted for 11% of India's arms imports in 2013-17. Russia, the country's top arms supplier, accounted for 62% India's arms imports in 2013–17, followed by the US (15%) and Israel (11%).
- Proposals for joint ventures under the Make in India initiative including transfer of technology as well as joint R&D in defence and security fields.
- Joint Working Group on Counter-Terrorism.
- Cooperation in the areas of border management, internal security and public safety, police modernization and capacity building for combating crime, crime prevention and cybercrime were established by the committee.

Economic and Commercial Relations

- From US\$ 200 million in 1992 (comprising primarily trade in diamonds), bilateral trade stood at \$10.8 billion (2022-23).
- India is Israel's second largest trade partner in Asia and ninth largest globally.
- In recent years, Israel has taken a strategic decision to strengthen economic relations with India, China and Japan.
- The huge gas reserves in the Mediterranean Sea off the Tel Aviv coast could be a potential area of cooperation.

Agriculture:

- 22 India-Israel Centres of Excellence for cooperation in agriculture have been inaugurated so far, of the 28 centres that are planned as of now.
- India has benefited from Israeli expertise and technologies in horticulture mechanization, protected cultivation, orchard and canopy management, nursery management, micro- irrigation and post-harvest management particularly in Haryana and Maharashtra.
- Israeli drip irrigation technologies and products are now widely used in India. Recently, an Indian company Jain Irrigation acquired 100% stakes of an Israeli drip-irrigation company, Naandan.

Water Management: Israel is known as the land of innovations in water management using techniques like desalination and wastewater treatment. This is beneficial for water- stressed India.

India's policy on Israel-Palestine issue:

1. India's policy on Israel-Palestine conflict has seen a shift. It has gone from being unequivocally pro-Palestine for the first four decades, to a tense balancing act with its three-decade-old friendly ties with Israel. In recent years, India's position has also been perceived as pro-Israel.
2. Since 2014, India has abstained many times from voting on Israel- Palestine issue.
3. During visit by PLO chief Mahmoud Abbas in 2017, the reference to East Jerusalem went missing.

4. Since 2017, there is omission of any reference to East Jerusalem as the capital of a Palestinian state. There is hyphenation of “Haram Al Sharif/Temple Mount”, equating claims of both Israel and Palestine.
5. In February 2018, Modi became the first Indian Prime Minister to visit Israel without a parallel visit to Palestine. This was de-hyphenation of the relationship. India would deal with each separately.

India-Iran Relations

Independent India and Iran established diplomatic relations on 15 March 1950. During much of the Cold War, relations between India and the erstwhile Imperial State of Iran suffered due to their differing political interests: India endorsed a non-aligned position but fostered strong links with the Soviet Union, while Iran was an open member of the Western Bloc and enjoyed close ties with the United States.

After the Iranian revolution in 1979, relations between the two states strengthened momentarily. However, Iran's continued support for Pakistan in the India–Pakistan conflict and India's close relations with Iraq during the Iran–Iraq War greatly strained bilateral ties.

India and Iran signed a defence cooperation agreement in December 2002.

Significance:

1. In the absence of cooperation from Pakistan, India's route to reaching Afghanistan, Central Asia, Eastern Europe and beyond.
2. A regional military power.
3. Located at the key choke point along Strait of Hormuz and Persian Gulf.
4. Key partner in stabilising Afghanistan and shared concern about terror emanating from there.
5. Critical to India's energy security diversification.
6. Opportunity for investment in connectivity initiatives, energy projects, fertiliser plants etc.
7. Market for Indian products like rice, tea etc.
8. Cultural and civilizational linkages.

Connectivity: Iran is key to India's connectivity with Central Asia and Eastern Europe. Both nations are members of INSTC and Ashgabat agreement.

Energy Cooperation: Iran has been central to India's energy security. However, the energy trade is limited due to US sanctions on Iran.

Investment: India has invested in Chabahar port. Investment in Railways (Chabahar to Zahedan) and Farzad B gas reserves could not materialise due to Western sanctions and delay in investment on the part of India.

In September 2022, Iran has offered ONGC Videsh Ltd (OVL) and its partners a 30% interest in development of the Farzad-B gas field in the Persian Gulf.

Recently, India and Iran signed a 10-year agreement for the operation of Chabahar port on the Gulf of Oman in southeastern Iran. Under the agreement, India is to invest \$120 million in the development of infrastructure in the Shahid Beheshti terminal at the port and extend a \$250 million credit line to Iran.

Challenges:

1. Iran's animosity with the USA and the West.
2. Iran's Nuclear ambitions
3. Continuous sanctions by the USA and West limits scope for Economic Cooperation.
4. Iran's hostilities with nations in the region like Saudi Arabia and Israel.
5. Iran's involvement in destabilising the region through proxies.
6. A hardline leadership in Iran, its position on Kashmir issue and frequent commentary on India internal matters.
7. Iran is part of BRI initiative and is increasingly getting closer to China. Both have signed a 25-year \$400 billion agreement.
8. Delay in project execution by India has led to Iran cancelling Indian projects. E.g.- Farzad-b gas field

Limitations (Chabahar):

- Increasing its footprint via Chabahar runs into trouble with U.S. sanctions again at a time India-U. S. ties are at their closest.
- There are questions on impact on India-Israel relation particularly after I2U2, which has inimical relations with Iran.
- Not increasing its cooperation with Iran and building on possibilities offered by Chabahar would mean India losing the connectivity race to its western flank entirely, as well as its plans to circumvent Pakistan.
- The \$400 billion China-Iran connectivity project of 2020 could upend India's plans inside Iran as well.
- Activation of IMEC corridor can further limit the utility of Chabahar port.

India has exported wheat and other goods to Afghanistan via Chabahar. MEA had allocated ₹ 100 crore for Chabahar Port for 2024-25. Recently, Russia has sent two trains carrying coal to India through the INSTC via Bandar Abbas port. India is planning to use Chabahar for Coal import from Russia.

India – Saudi Arabia Relations

Saudi Arabia has been a strategic partner of India since the signing of the Riyadh Declaration in 2010.

Economic Relations:

- In FY 2019-20, bilateral trade was valued at US \$33.09 billion, which has increased to \$52.76 billion in 2022-23.
- India as the kingdom's second largest trading partner and Saudi Arabia as India's fourth largest trading partner.

- India's major exports include basmati rice, textiles and garments and machinery, while it imports organic and inorganic chemicals, metal scrap, leather, gold and oil from Saudi Arabia.
- Both nations are expected to expand trade and cooperation and joint ventures in telecommunications, pharmaceuticals, health services, information technology, biotechnology, agriculture, construction projects, energy and financial services.
- During his visit to New Delhi in February 2019, the Crown Prince had committed to invest over \$100 billion in sectors of priority in India. In September 2023, both sides agreed to set up a joint working group (JWG) to channelise the \$100 billion in investments promised.
 - \$50 billion was earmarked for the West Coast refinery, a mega plant to be set up by Saudi Aramco, Abu Dhabi National Oil Company (ADNOC) and Indian firms.

Strategic Partnership Council Agreement

- India-Saudi Strategic Partnership Council was formed to coordinate on strategically important issues.
- The council will be headed by the Prime Minister and Crown Prince Mohammed and will meet every two years.
- India is the fourth country with which Saudi Arabia has formed such a strategic partnership, after the UK, France and China.
- The first meeting of the Strategic Partnership Council took place in September 2023, co-chaired by Indian PM and Saudi Crown Prince.
 - Both sides extended their full support to the early implementation of the West Coast refinery project.
 - Two sides agreed to expedite negotiations for a free trade agreement (FTA) between India and the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC)

Energy Cooperation:

- Saudi Arabia is currently India's third-largest supplier of crude oil – providing about 18 % of its energy needs. It also has a major role in India's Strategic Petroleum Reserves (SPRs).
- 32% of the LPG requirements of India are met by Saudi Arabia.

Indian expatriates: The 4.1 million-strong Indian community in Saudi Arabia is the largest expatriate community in the Kingdom and is the 'most preferred community' due to their expertise, sense of discipline, law-abiding and peace-loving nature.

Pilgrimage and culture: Haj pilgrimage is another important component of bilateral relations. India sends second highest pilgrims after Indonesia.

Recent Shifts:

- India is showing signs of overcoming its reluctance to forge security partnerships with the Gulf states whose security apparatuses had long been closely associated with Pakistan.

- India and Saudi Arabia are moving from a purely buyer-seller relationship towards a closer strategic partnership that will include Saudi investments in downstream oil and gas projects.
- Saudi Arabia took a positive approach towards abrogation of Article 370 in Jammu and Kashmir.
- India fits perfectly into Saudi Vision 2030, aimed at reducing dependency on oil, diversifying Saudi economy and making it a modern, vibrant society.
- The UAE and Qatar recently held good talks with Iran. Iranian President has already visited Qatar and Oman this year.
- Iran and Saudi Arabia have held five rounds of talks in Baghdad.
- Saudi Crown Prince visited Turkey in June 2022, which was first visit since murder of Jamal Khasoggi.

Saudi vision 2030: A centralised development plan under which Saudi Arabia will undergo a transition phase from the long-established conservative Muslim society to a path of modernisation. The country will focus on sectors such as tourism, housing, defence, trade, and investments to diversify the sources of economic revenue.

Under Saudi Vision 2030, **Saudi Green Initiative** was launched, aimed at increasing Saudi's reliance on clean energy, offsetting emission and protecting the environment. Aims at about 50% energy through renewable and clean sources by 2030.

I2U2

It involves India, Israel, UAE, and USA. It is also termed as QUAD West. The platform is an initiative of USA to strengthen alliances in the region after Abraham accord. The first meeting of the group took place virtually in October 2021. First summit-level meeting took place in July 2022.

- It is also seen as normalising Israel's relationship with the Arab world and developing a common front against Iran.
- It is also an effort of USA to present India as an alternative to China for the West Asian nations.
- The initiative can reduce tensions and bring stability to the region.
- The goal of USA is to reduce its presence from West Asia so that it can focus in the Indo-Pacific and managing China.
- Presence of India underscores the acceptance of India stakes in West Asia and West Asian nations' eagerness to engage with India beyond trade.
- Normal relationship between Israel and gulf nations will give greater manoeuvring space for India in the region.
- It could advance India's strategic playing ground beyond the Gulf into the Levant and eastern Mediterranean, when the new group embraces Greece, Cyprus and Egypt within its ambit.
- The UAE is a trading hub for India due their ease of business rules. After having turned its back to RCEP, Dubai can be that hub for India to tap new markets.

- It gives the US a qualitatively different re-entry point back into the region as a partner, rather than a hegemon, at a time when China is trying to create a place for itself in the region.

Challenges:

I2U2 has three of Iran's enemies coming together. Many in Iran have been watching with dismay India's growing closeness to the US and Israel, therefore India might have to work harder to assuage Iranian sensitivities.

India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC)



- The MoU for IMEC was signed on September 10, 2023, during the **2023 G20 New Delhi summit by India, United States, United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia, France, Germany, Italy, and the European Union.**
- It is part of the broader **Partnership for Global Infrastructure and Investment (PGII)**, which focuses on infrastructure development in economically developing regions.
- It aims to integrate **Asia, Europe, and the Middle East**, enhancing economic cooperation across these regions.

IMEC comprises two primary corridors:

1. **East Corridor:** Linking India to the Arabian Gulf.
2. **Northern Corridor:** Connecting the Gulf region to Europe.

Additionally, it encompasses various infrastructure components such as **railway networks, ship-to-rail connections, road transport routes**, electricity cables, hydrogen pipelines, and high-speed data cables.

Objectives:

1. Improve transportation efficiency, lower costs, and promote economic cohesion among participating nations.
2. Generate employment opportunities and reduce Greenhouse Gas (GHG) emissions.
3. Facilitate trade and connectivity, thereby reshaping regional integration among Asia, Europe, and the Middle East.

Significance:

1. It will help in linking South Asia with Europe, deepening trade and connectivity.
2. It will strengthen India's economic linkages with West Asia, expanding India's stake in the West Asian region.
3. Cost-effective and time-effective route from South Asia to Europe.
4. Can be an alternative to Belt and Road Initiative.
5. With Saudi Arabi and Israel part of the corridor, it can help in normalizing their relations, ushering stability in West Asia.
6. Provide alternative to Suez Canal Route-Bring stability to global commerce

Challenges:

1. Instability in West Asia- Ongoing Israel-Hamas conflict has created challenges to its implementation.
2. Delays in execution of the project.
3. Competitor to Chabahar
4. May be seen as India's tilt towards Israel and Saudi Arabi and complicate India's relations with Iran

Recent decline in Saudi-USA Relations:

- Saudi Arabia has ends 50-year petrodollar deal with US. Saudi Arabia can now sell oil and other goods using different currencies, such as the Chinese RMB, Euros, Yen, and Yuan, instead of only US dollars.
- Obama administration decision to sign JCPOA and remove sanctions on Iran.
- Saudi assertive policy under Prince Salman. E.g.- Blockade of Qatar, Intervention in Yemen
- Killing of Jamal Khashoggi and Biden's vow during election campaign to isolate Saudi prince.
- US ended support for Saudi operation in Yemen, including related weapon transfer.
- US is reducing its engagements in the Gulf and Saudi Arabia is looking to diversify its security partners.
- Western attempt of Price cap on Russia- seen as a power shift from producers to consumers.
- China negotiating truce between Saudi Arabia and Iran has been seen a coup against USA in West Asia China's emergence as a key regional player

Gulf states' issues with USA:

1. Prince Mohammed bin Salman was angered by Biden's vow at the outset of his administration to consider him a pariah over Jamal Khashoggi murder.
2. They are aggrieved due to lack of support of Biden administration against Houthis in Yemen and Shia militias on its refineries.
3. US restriction on arms sales as undermining Washington's traditional role as underwriter of its security needs.
4. USA's attempts to revive nuclear deal with Iran
5. Conditionalities put by USA and its pressure to take sides in geopolitical competition.
6. Attempts at putting the price cap on energy shifts the power from producers to consumers. Gulf states and concerned about it as they can be the next target.

Saudi Arabia-Iran Deal (Brokered by China)

In March 2023, Iran and Saudi Arabia agreed to re-establish relations after years of hostility.

Both nations agreed to **re-establish diplomatic ties, respect each other's sovereignty and maintain non-interference in the other's domestic affairs.**

The agreement also reinstates two previous accords:

- I. On security cooperation signed in 2001
- II. Dealing with economic, technical, scientific, and cultural ties, signed in 1998.

This agreement ends seven years of diplomatic estrangement between the two Gulf neighbours. Previous attempts brokered by Iraq and Oman had not succeeded in any breakthrough.

China's Foreign Minister Wang Yi, described deal as a **"victory for dialogue, a victory for peace."** This goes against impression about the US in Ukraine crisis, where there is no dialogue or diplomatic breakthrough.

Importance Factors:

1. **For West Asian nations**, China is an attractive partner. It has substantial energy, trade, investment, and technology-related ties with West Asia. It is the region's largest buyer of crude oil, a major trade and investment partner, and is also rapidly expanding its role as a technology-provider in most countries.
2. Both Iran and Saudi Arabia have paid a heavy financial price for their rivalry from Syria to Yemen. There is also concern about a **shadow war escalating into a larger conflict**.
3. **Iran:** Hampered by US sanctions, Iran has moved to deepen its relations with Russia and now China. In turning to Beijing to mediate with the Saudis, **Iran is elevating China** in the region and seeking to **escape the isolation imposed by Washington**.
4. **Saudi Arabia:** The priority for the kingdom is to end the Yemen conflict. The lethal attacks from the precision missiles of the Houthis, said to have been provided by Iran, are a threat to national infrastructure and morale.
5. Saudi Arabia is also diversifying its engagements beyond USA and looking for new partners.

6. **For China**, West Asia is crucial for the **realisation of China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)**, with regional states being important for **logistical connectivity, and investment, consultancy, and contracting partnerships**.
7. China has been seeking **military bases of its own in the region** as it pursues **energy resources and influence beyond Asia**. China's interests require a stable regional environment.
8. The deal "boosts Beijing's ability to project an image of itself as a constructive actor for peace. The normalisation is also being linked with **ultra-right government in Israel** and limiting the window of engagement between Saudi and Israel. The deal can dash Israel's hopes for normal ties with Saudi Arabi and an anti-Iranian coalition with Saudi Arabia.

Challenges:

- **Saudi-Iran differences will be difficult to resolve:** They result from Saudi Arabia's deep sense of strategic vulnerability vis-à-vis its northern neighbour and concerns that might destabilise regional states through the use of Shia proxies.
- There are doubts about change in Iran's approach till JCPOA is signed again.
- Polarised polity in both USA and Israel, Upcoming Presidential elections in the USA further limit scope for any US waiver to Iran.
- Israel's profound apprehensions about Tehran's nuclear program is another challenge. Israel has said that it'll take military actions against any Iranian nuclear program.
- Since Saudi Arabia has deep security cooperation with the USA, a larger security role by Beijing in the region remains doubtful. So, Beijing is no position to enforce the agreement.
- There are apprehensions about Iran limiting its export of ideology and footprints across the region under the present conservative leadership in Tehran. The agreement seems to be an outcome of compulsion emerging from diplomatic isolation.

Suggestion:

- Iran will need to play a more pro-active role to assure its neighbour of its benign intentions, an effort that would gain credibility with China's active engagement with the two regional powers.
- Need for revival of JCPOA, managing Israel's aggressive actions.

Xi Jinping visit to Saudi Arabia

Purpose: To attend the first China-Arab States Summit and the China-GCC Summit and on state visit to Saudi Arabia. This is his first to Saudi Arabia since 2016.

- Both elevated the ties to Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.
- Both agreed to hold summits every two years.
- The joint statement showed alignment on most issues from space research, digital economy and infrastructure to Iran's nuclear program, the Yemen war and Russia's war on Ukraine.
- Xi urged his GCC counterparts to "make full use of the Shanghai Petrol and Gas Exchange as a platform to conduct oil and gas sales using Chinese currency."

Chinese Interests in West Asia:

1. China sees Saudi Arabia as its key ally in the Middle East as the biggest oil supplier.
2. A shared suspicion of Western countries, especially on issues such as human rights.
3. Joint investment in China for refinery and petrochemical complex
4. China looks to deepen its relationships with countries in the Middle East amid growing strains in its ties with the US and other Western nations.

Saudi and Gulf Interests:

1. Saudi Arabia and Gulf states have been deepening ties with Russia and China over recent years as US commitment to the region has come under question.
2. Saudi Arabia sided with Russia and did not delay cut in oil production.
3. Gulf states don't want to take sides in polarize world and want to keep their options open.
4. They see China as a reliable long-term customer which needs energy.
5. They also need Chinese investment and technology cooperation to diversify their economy and prepare themselves for a post-fossil fuel world.
6. They are also attempting to diversify their security partnership beyond USA.

USA-Iran

- Negotiation with Iran on restoring JCPOA has been going on through back-channels. Both sides are accusing each other of not being serious.
- West imposed sanctions on Iran for supplying drones to Russia during Ukraine crisis and Human Rights sanctions to punish Tehran's response to protests in the wake of 22-year old Mahsa Amini death in police custody has further complicated the matter. Iran has accused the West of organising Unrest in Iran.
- In February 2023, Bloomberg reported about IAEA inspectors finding enrichment to 84%, close to 90% required for making a bomb. However, Iran has maintained that it does not want a bomb.
- **Israel** has said that "all possible means" are on the table to prevent Iran from getting a nuclear weapon.
- During Joe Biden's trip to West Asia, USA and Israel signed a joint strategic declaration reinforcing a common front against Iran, where the US vowed to use "all elements in its national power" to stop Tehran from acquiring nuclear weapons. President Biden has said that the U.S. would use force, if need be, to prevent Iran from developing a bomb. He also said that Israel would be safer with a new US nuclear deal with Iran.
- Washington has put Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) on foreign terrorist list. Biden has said that IRGC won't be taken off the list even if that meant no nuclear deal.
- On Nuclear deal negotiations, Israel has taken a strong stance. It has said that diplomacy won't stop Iran from going nuclear. It asked USA to "put a credible military threat on the table."

Abraham Accord

It refers to the agreement reached between Israel, Bahrain and the UAE to normalise relations between the three. This has been brokered by the USA. marked the first public normalization of relations between an Arab country and Israel since that of Jordan in 1994. Later on, Sudan and Morocco also joined it.

- As per the agreements, the UAE and Bahrain will establish Embassies and exchange ambassadors with Israel.
- Both will work together with Israel across a range of sectors, including tourism, trade, healthcare and security.
- The Accords also open the door for Muslims around the world to visit the historic sites in Israel and to peacefully pray at Al-Aqsa Mosque in Jerusalem, the third holiest site in Islam.

Challenges: The ongoing conflict between Israel and Hamas presents biggest challenge to the accord since it has resulted in animosity towards Israel on the Arab streets. Since the beginning, Palestinians has believed that the Accords are in the interests of Israel.

Israel-Palestine Conflict

History of the Conflict

In 1947, the United Nations adopted Resolution 181, known as the **Partition Plan**, which sought to divide the British Mandate of Palestine into Arab and Jewish states. On May 14, 1948, the State of Israel was created, sparking the first Arab-Israeli War. The war ended in 1949 with Israel's victory, but 750,000 Palestinians were displaced, and the territory was divided into 3 parts: the State of Israel, the West Bank (of the Jordan River), and the Gaza Strip.

Six-Day War (June 1967): Between Israel and a coalition of Arab states, primarily Egypt, Syria, and Jordan. Israel emerged victorious and occupies a total of 70,000 sq km, including The Golan Heights from Syria, West Bank including East Jerusalem from Jordan and Gaza Strip and Sinai Peninsula from Egypt.

Yom Kippur War (October 1973): between Israel and a coalition of Arab states led by Egypt and Syria. The war ended in a stalemate. It led to realisation between both sides of their limitations paving way for Palestinian peace process and signing of Camp David Accords.

Camp David Accords: a peace treaty that ended the thirty-year conflict between Egypt and Israel. Israel returned Sinai Peninsula to Egypt and Egypt-Israel peace



treaty was signed in 1979, making Egypt the first Arab state to recognize Israel.

Oslo Accords: a pair of interim agreements between Israel and the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO). Both Israel and PLO recognized each other and beginning of peace process. The process was opposed by a large portion of Palestinian population and Right-wing Israelis. However, it could not be successful.

Present Status of Conflict:

- On October 7, 2023, Hamas launched its deadly attack on Israel with rockets and stormed southern Israeli cities and towns killing more than 1300 Israelis, injuring over 3300 taking hundreds of hostages. In response, Israel declared war on Hamas, launched aerial campaigns and ground operations within the Gaza Strip to rescue the hostages and penalise Hamas for its actions.
- Almost two million Gazans i.e. more than 85 percent of the population have fled their homes since October 2023 and more than 40,000 have been killed.
- Neither Hamas nor Israel have agreed to the terms laid out by U.S. President Joe Biden for a ceasefire and hostage release.

Conflict expanding across the region:

1. On April 1, Israel launched an airstrike on an Iranian consular building in Syria killing multiple senior Iranian military officers. In response, Iran launched 300 drones and missiles at Israel on April 13 but damage to Israel was minimal. This was first ever direct attack by Iran on Israel.
2. On July 19, the Iran-backed Houthis launched drone attack on Israel hitting an apartment building in Tel Aviv. The next day, Israel made an airstrike on the strategic port of Hodeida in Yemen killing six, injured dozens more and left ablaze key oil facilities in the area.
3. Hezbollah air strike in the Golan Heights (under Israeli Occupation) killed twelve children. On 31st July, Israel air strike killed Hezbollah top commander responsible for attack, in Beirut.
4. On 31st July, Ismail Haniyeh, the political leader of Hamas, was assassinated in Iran. Hamas and Iran blamed Israel for the assassination.

Challenges:

1. Many humanitarian agencies suspended their operations after Israel airstrike killed seven World Centre Kitchen employees. The World Food Programme warns famine is now imminent in Gaza.
2. The attack on medical infrastructure and lack of basic supplies has led to only eleven out of thirty-five hospitals in the strip remain partially. The WHO has warned of disease spread along with mounting civilian casualties.
3. Neighbouring Egypt and Jordan are unwilling to absorb more Palestinian refugees fearing that will not be allowed to return once they leave.
4. Egypt also fears that Hamas fighters entering Egypt could trigger a new war in the Sinai Peninsula by launching attacks on Israel or destabilizing the Sisi regime by supporting the Muslim Brotherhood.

5. The concern about conflict expanding to the broader region, destabilizing the whole region and impacting critical sea Lanes of Communication across the Suez Canal. Attack by Houthis and Hezbollah on Israel indicate towards the same.
6. Houthis have been targeting the ships crossing the Red Sea, creating challenges for global commerce. From October 2023 to March 2024, the **Houthis attacked** more than 60 vessels in the Red Sea. To avoid **attack**, hundreds of commercial vessels have been rerouted to sail around South Africa.
7. It has led to protests across the world, mainly in western nations, in favour of Gaza people.

Challenges for India

1. Middle East accounts for 44 per cent of India's total crude oil imports during April 2023. A conflict-ridden Middle East would likely result in increased oil prices, posing challenges to India's energy security.
2. Challenges for India's exports to West Asia and Europe due to disruption along Sea Lanes of Communication.
3. Balancing India's relations with three poles in West Asia will become extremely difficult.
4. Expansion of conflict beyond Israel and Gaza can create challenges for safety of huge Indian diaspora in West Asia.
5. With Israel involved in the conflict, it could disrupt and delay critical defence consignments from Israel.
6. Delay in implementation of IMEC corridor.
7. Domestic sentiments in favour of people of Gaza.

India's Response:

1. India has strongly condemned the terror attacks on Israel on 07 October 2023 and the loss of civilian lives in the ongoing Israel-Hamas conflict.
2. India has called for restraint and de-escalation and emphasized peaceful resolution of the conflict through dialogue and diplomacy.
3. India has sent multiple batches of humanitarian aid Palestine includes essential life-saving medicines, surgical items, tents, sleeping bags, tarpaulins, sanitary utilities, water purification tablets among other necessary items.
4. India also releases \$2.5 million to United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East (UNRWA) for Palestinian refugees
5. Arab League has praised **India's** steadfast dedication to **Palestine** includes **humanitarian aid** and support for a two-state solution.

Probable Questions:

1. Highlighting the significance of I2U2, discuss the benefits it can bring to India. Also enumerate the challenges in its implementation.
2. Abraham accord is a visionary initiative of the USA for West Asia. Explain. Discuss the challenges associated with implementation of the accord.

3. The signing of the Accords has helped remove strategic obstacles for New Delhi and aided defence cooperation. Analyse. Also discuss the challenges involved.
4. Chinese engagements in the Gulf pose a strategic challenge for USA as well as India. Discuss the recent trajectory of India-Gulf relations.

AFRICA

Significance

1. Africa is home to over half a dozen of the fastest growing countries of this decade such as Rwanda, Senegal, and Tanzania etc. making it one of the **growth poles** of the world.
2. Africa is among the youngest continent with fastest growing population with a combined GDP of 2.5 trillion dollars this makes it an Ideal market and investment destination.
3. Africa is a resource rich continent dominated by commodities like crude oil, gas, pulses and lentils, leather, gold and other metals. This provides for economic Complementarities.
4. The energy resources with Africa is key to the diversification strategy of many developing nations like India and China.
5. The number of countries in Africa make it an important block for voting at platforms like UN and WTO.
6. Africa has emerged as new battleground for major powers like India, China, USA and Europe to increase influence due to its resource richness, economic potential and voting power at global platforms.
7. The instability in Africa due to civil wars external interventions and terrorism has resulted in refugee crisis. This has added another layer to the challenges of geopolitics.
8. Geographically, Africa becomes important due to its location around critical sea lanes like Bab el mandeb and Suez Canal.

African Union:

1. The bloc was founded on 26 May 2001 in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia, and launched on 9 July 2002 in Durban, South Africa. It is a Union of 55 member states. The highest decision-making organ is the Assembly of the African Union, made up of all the heads of state or government of member states of the AU.

Agenda 2063:

Agenda 2063 is a set of initiatives proposed and currently under implementation by the African Union. It was adopted on 31 January 2015. The stated goals of the agenda are **economic development** (including the eradication of poverty within one generation), **political integration** (in particular through the establishment of a federal or confederate United Africa), **improvements in democracy and justice**, establishment of security and peace on the entire African continent, strengthening of cultural identity through an "African renaissance" and pan-African ideals, gender equality, and political independence from foreign powers.

AfCFTA

The African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) is a free trade area founded in 2018, with trade commencing as of 1 January 2021. It was created by the African Continental Free Trade Agreement among 54 of the 55 African Union nations. The free-trade area is the largest in the world in terms of the number of participating countries since the formation of the World Trade Organization.

India- Africa Relations

During struggle for independence, India always advocated for anti-colonialism and anti-imperialism in Africa. After Independence India took up the cause of decolonisation of African continent through the platform of Afro Asian Summit, Bandung Declaration of 1955 and NAM. End of racial struggle and decolonization became the rallying point of India–Africa relations.

However the relationship suffered because of instability in the African continent and India's focus on protectionism and import substitution. Since the beginning of 21st century, the relationship has grown by leaps and bounds across multiple sectors like economy, security, capacity building, tackling climate change etc.

Economic Relations:

- India's economic relations with Africa are truly multi-faceted, with the Indian Government extending timely grant-in aid to African countries, concessional lines of credit (LOCs), capacity building and technical assistance, supporting major projects in Africa, establishment of industrial units, among others.
- The India-Africa bilateral trade has been growing steadily, year-on-year, with the trade volume touching almost \$100 billion in 2022-23. India is the fifth largest investor in Africa with cumulative investments of **\$ 54 billion**.
- India has also signed bilateral trade agreements with more than 20 African countries.
- Africa has been one of the largest beneficiaries of Government of India's LOCs that currently amount to more than US\$ 6.3 billion out of an overall commitment of US\$ 10 billion.
- India's Duty-Free Tariff Preference Scheme (DFTP) for Least Developed Countries (LDCs) has benefitted 38 African countries and contributed to the expansion of India-Africa bilateral trade,
- In pursuance of trilateral cooperation with Africa, India is collaborating with Japan and Kenya to build a cancer hospital and is collaborating with UAE to set up a centre of IT Excellence in Ethiopia.

Political Engagements:

- India has setup **India-Africa Forum Summit (IAFS)** as a dedicated platform for engagement between India and African nations. Both India and Africa have aligned with each other on the platforms like Climate Change Negotiations, UNSC reforms and WTO.
- The Government of India identified 18 African countries including Burkina Faso, Cameroon, Cape Verde, Rwanda, Somalia, among others where new missions would be opened. This will result in Indian missions in 47 out of 54 countries.

Security Cooperation:

- In the post-colonial Africa India had assisted to set up military academy in Ethiopia, defence college and Naval war college in Nigeria besides setting up air force in Ghana and training military personnel in number of African countries.
- India have had defence partnerships with Zambia, Nigeria, Ghana, Ethiopia. Botswana, Uganda, Namibia and Mozambique and is seeking to expand this to include more countries across the vast continent.
- India has coastal surveillance radar networks along Madagascar, Mauritius and Seychelles.
- East African nations share boundary with Indo-Pacific region and are key to augmenting India's strategy with respect to maritime security. East African nations form a critical part of India's Indo-Pacific strategy with India having signed multiple defence, trade and shipping agreements over the last few years.
- India is one of the largest contributors to peacekeeping in Africa and has participated in all the UN peacekeeping missions in Africa
- India has also built up its credentials as the first responder as in times of crisis in the Indian Ocean region.
- The first-ever India Africa Defence Ministers Conclave (IADMC) was held in Lucknow in conjunction with DefExpo in 2020. The dialogue will be conducted alongside every defence Expo.

Energy Cooperation:

- India imports around 15% of its energy needs from Africa. Energy cooperation is also a key subset of India's development partnership with Africa. Under the International Solar Alliance (ISA) a sizeable share of India's concessional credit has been earmarked to Africa.
- Africa is an important component of One Sun One World One Grid project under International Solar Alliance.
- India and Morocco will explore joint electrification projects in Africa.

Diaspora Relations:

There is More than 3,000,000 people of Indian descendants in Africa. Indian Diaspora in Africa constitutes 12.37 per cent of the total Diaspora of India. A large chunk of Indian diaspora continues to live in African countries such as Kenya, Uganda, Mauritius, and Nigeria.

- India is also seeking to reinvigorate its cultural links with East Africa under the rubric of Project 'Mausam', an initiative of the Ministry of Culture.

Education and Capacity Building:

- India is investing in capacity building providing more than \$1 billion in technical assistance and training to personnel under the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) program.
- India has invested **\$100 million** in the Pan-African E-Network to bridge the digital divide in Africa, leveraging its strengths in information technology.
- India is also helping Africa to bridge the digital divide through the 2nd phase of the pan-Africa e-Network project – e-VidyaBharati and e-ArogyaBharati Network Project, which aims to provide

5-years free tele-education to 4,000 students, free medical education to 1,000 doctors/nurses/paramedics and free medical consultancy.

- Solar Mamas trained at Barefoot college in Rajasthan and playing key role in solarisation of Africa.

Developmental Initiatives:

India has executed 194 developmental projects in 37 African countries and is currently working to complete 77 more projects in 29 countries in the continent, with a total outlay of USD 11.6 billion.

India and Japan have jointly launched Asian Africa Growth Corridor To boost connectivity in Asia and Africa and compete against China's BRI.

The India- EU connectivity partnership includes Africa as an area of collaboration with a value-based approach.

India Africa Forum Summit:

The India–Africa Forum Summit (IAFS) is the official platform for the African-Indian relations. IAFS will be held once in every three years. First Summit- 2008, Second Summit- 2011

Third Summit- 2015: Third summit was the largest-ever turnout of African leaders in India. Leadership from all 54 African nations were present. The fourth summit has been postponed due to Covid-19 pandemic.

Assistance during Covid-19:

Under India's landmark '**Vaccine Maitri**' initiative, India gifted 150 metric tonnes of medical supplies to 25 African countries. In addition, India supplied 25 million doses of vaccines that were produced within the country to 42 countries in the African region.

India's Approach towards Africa: - AS stated by the PM Modi.

1. Africa will be at the top of our priorities. We will continue to intensify and deepen our engagement with Africa. As we have shown, it will be sustained and regular.
2. Our development partnership will be guided by your priorities. We will build as much local capacity and create local opportunities as possible. It will be on terms that are comfortable to you, that will liberate your potential and not constrain your future.
3. We will keep our markets open and make it easier and more attractive to trade with India. We will support our industry to invest in Africa.
4. We will harness India's experience with the digital revolution to support Africa's development; improve delivery of public services; extend education and health; spread digital literacy; expand financial inclusion; and mainstream the marginalised.
5. Africa has 60 percent of the world's arable land, but produces just 10 percent of the global output. We will work with you to improve Africa's agriculture.
6. Our partnership will address the challenges of climate change.
7. We will strengthen our cooperation and mutual capabilities in combating terrorism and extremism; keeping our cyberspace safe and secure; and, supporting the UN in advancing and keeping peace.

8. We will work with African nations to keep the oceans open and free for the benefit of all nations. The world needs cooperation and competition in the eastern shores of Africa and the eastern Indian Ocean.
9. As global engagement in Africa increases, we must all work together to ensure that Africa does not once again turn into a theatre of rival ambitions, but becomes a nursery for the aspirations of Africa's youth.
10. Just as India and Africa fought colonialism together, we will work together for a just, representative and democratic global order that has a voice for one-third of humanity that lives in Africa and India.

Challenges:

1. Limited economic muscle, delay in project execution leads to mistrust about Indian commitments.
2. Lack of any grand strategy or dedicated policy in engagement with Africa.
3. Disconnect between India's development assistance to Africa and economic engagement with the continent.
4. India's development funds are channelized through African Union without significant role of Indian embassies in respective countries.
5. Mistreatment of African students and visitors in India generates animosity within African society.
6. Indian projects face challenge not only from China, but also from Europe and USA.
7. No project has been announced under Asia Africa growth corridor, seen as an alternative to BRI.
8. Lack of regular engagements. IAFS meetings have been too few and irregularly.

China in Africa:

1. China is Africa's largest trade partner with bilateral trade more than \$254 billion. It is 4th largest investor with total investment of \$43 billion.
2. Total Chinese loan to Africa is more than \$148 billion, making it single largest creditor to Africa.
3. China's first overseas military base is Djibouti, in the horn of Africa.
4. 39 countries from Africa support the BRI, with mostly coastal nations.

Forum on China–Africa Cooperation (FOCAC)- Held regularly every three years. Til now, eight summits have taken place, latest one in 2021. The next summit will take place from 5th September 2024.

Security Cooperation:

1. China supports Africa's military transformation by providing equipment, advanced technology, and independent capacity-building.
2. The "China-Africa Defence and Security Forum" is an important development in this context as it promises to be a major ideation forum.

Challenges:

1. the unilateral nature of the initiative, the lack of transparency and accountability to African countries, and the absence of projects that directly benefit locals have raised suspicions and fuelled local resentment.
2. Frequent local protests and harassing and kidnapping of Chinese workers in countries like Nigeria, Uganda and Tanzania.

India Vs. China in Africa

1. At 3rd IAFS, India offered \$10 billion investment, while at the 2018 Forum for China–Africa Cooperation in Beijing, China offered Africa \$60 billion for development financing until 2021.
2. Because of the social capital India has in Africa, its presence is welcomed by African countries in a way that China's is not.
3. China goes for large infrastructure projects while India is mainly focussed on HICDPs and capacity building initiatives.
4. Chinese projects are extractive and strategically located while India's projects are as per needs of respective countries and funds are handled by African Union.
5. Some of Indian initiatives like Solar Mamas have been globally acknowledged.

Suggestions:

1. To overcome the China challenge in Africa, increased cooperation between India and its international allies should be priority. The recent India-EU Summit has identified Africa as a region where a partnership-based approach will be followed.
2. The fourth summit, pending since last year, should be held as soon as possible, even if in a virtual format.
3. Rather than playing catch-up with China, India should leverage its own unique strength in areas like capacity building, entrepreneurship, MSME etc.
4. Undertake projects under AAGC and synergise between Act East and PQI.
5. Take direct control of development programme by involving respective missions, rather than handing it to AU intermediaries.
6. Disburse aid bilaterally and align it to national priorities of respective states to make them stakeholders.

Central Asia

Central Asia consists of the former Soviet republics of Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan. Central Asia has a population of about 82 million, in five countries: Kazakhstan (18 million), Kyrgyzstan (6 million), Tajikistan (9 million), Turkmenistan (6 million), and Uzbekistan (35 million).

Importance of Central Asia:

- The region is said to be an 'arena of great game' being played out between Russia, China, US, Turkey, Iran, Europe, EU, Japan, Pakistan, India, and Afghanistan, all of whom have substantial security and economic stakes in the region.
- Strategic Backyard of Russia and shares boundary with disturbed regions like Afghanistan and Xinjiang. It also acts as buffer between these regions and Eastern Europe.
- The region has become all the more important due to presence of Taliban in Afghanistan, China's Belt and Road Initiative and Russia's desire of reclaiming its lost glory.
- All these states are rich in minerals and well-endowed with hydroelectric resources. Kazakhstan has the world's second largest reserves of uranium and is the world's largest producer; Uzbekistan has large reserves of gas, uranium and gold; Turkmenistan has fourth largest reserves of natural gas; Tajikistan has huge hydroelectric potential; Kyrgyzstan is rich in gold and hydroelectric power.

India- Central Asia Relations

India and Central Asia have had longstanding historical, cultural, political, and economic relations that have over the time metamorphosed into a stable, mature, and transformational partnership.

- India has enjoyed historical and civilizational linkages with Central Asia through the Silk Route since 3rd century BC. Post independent India's linkages with the Soviet period through culture, music, dance, movies and literature sustained close relations with the Soviet Republics.
- Central Asian countries are part of India's "extended neighbourhood".
- We face common challenges such as terrorism, extremism, radicalisation, drug trafficking etc.

Significance for India:

- Key to stabilising Afghanistan and warding off security threats emanating from there.
- Strengthening India's presence in its extended neighbourhood and deepen cooperation with Russia.
- Energy security due to availability of uranium, oil and gas reserves
- Source of Raw Material for industries because of its mineral resources
- Lucrative market for Indian pharmaceutical products, agri-products, IT products and movies
- Opportunities for investment because of the developmental needs of Central Asian nations. These nations want to break away from Russia-China duopoly and thus look at India as a desired alternative.
- Avenue for cooperation between India and Russia.
- India's only overseas airbase lies in Farkhor, Tajikistan.

Bilateral Trade: Trade between India and Central Asia lies at a nearly \$2 billion compared to Chinese trade with the CARs, which roughly amounts to a \$100 billion.

Security Relations:

- Both India and Central Asia face common threats of religious extremism, fundamentalism and drug trafficking that poses challenges to regional stability.
- India conducts bilateral military exercises like Dustlik with Uzbekistan, Kazind with Kazakhstan and Khanjar with Kyrgyzstan.
- All five Central Asian nations also participated in recently conducted Delhi Regional security dialogue over stability of Afghanistan.
- Strategic Partnership Agreements (SPA): India signed the SPA with three of the five CARs—Kazakhstan, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan—to stimulate defence cooperation and deepen trade relations.

Connectivity Initiatives:

- To improve connectivity, India has concluded a trilateral agreement for renovation of Chabahar port.
- Development of the International North South Transport Corridor (INSTC) and has become a member of the Ashgabat Agreement.
- Though India is part of the Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-India (TAPI) pipeline, progress is slow.

Ashgabat Agreement: The pact was signed in 2011 by Uzbekistan, Turkmenistan, Iran, Oman and Qatar and aimed at developing the shortest trade route between the Central Asian republics and Iranian and Omani ports. India joined the Ashgabat agreement in 2018 to diversify its connectivity options with Central Asia.

Regional Groupings: India's membership of Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO). India is negotiating FTA with Eurasian Economic Union (EEU).

Capacity Building: India launched ITEC (Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation) programme to provide assistance to the CARs countries in the area of IT, Management, journalism, diplomacy, entrepreneurship, and banking.

Connect Central Asia Policy: Launched in 2012, which is a broad-based approach including political, security, economic, and cultural connections. The Connect Central Asia Policy is based on - 4Cs: Commerce, Connectivity, Consular and Community.

Opportunity for India: Though active partners in the BRI, the disenchantment of the Central Asian countries has increased not only with the growing Chinese footprint in their economic and political systems but also because of repression of several Kazakh and Kyrgyz Muslims along with Uighurs in the Xinjiang region, resulting in many anti-Chinese protests.

Recent Initiatives:

1. In July 2015, Indian prime minister visited all five Central Asian states during a single trip for the first time.
2. For economic engagement, India has established the India–Central Asia Development Group and India–Central Asia Business Council.
3. An NSA level summit held in New Delhi in November 2021 to discuss the security implications of the prevalent situation in Afghanistan included the NSAs of these 5 countries
4. The first India-Central Asia summit that took place in virtual format on 27 January, 2022. The leaders agreed to hold the summit every two years.
5. India-Central Asia dialogue mechanism at the Foreign Ministers level. Recently, the third dialogue took place.
6. India has announced \$1 billion Line of Credit aimed at High Impact Development Projects (HICDPS) for socio-economic development of the region.
7. In January 2022, there was a virtual summit between India and five Central Asian republics. Prime Minister pitched for “an integrated approach for regional connectivity and cooperation for the next 30 years”. Three main objectives of the summit were:
 - To make it clear that cooperation between India and Central Asia is essential for regional security and prosperity. From Indian point of view, Central Asia is central to India’s vision of an integrated and stable extended neighbourhood.
 - To give “an effective structure to our cooperation”. This will establish a framework of regular interactions at different levels and among various stakeholders.
 - To create an ambitious roadmap for our cooperation.

Challenges:

1. Lack of direct connectivity with the region.
2. Limited economic engagement.
3. Chinese footprints through BRI and China-Pakistan axis create challenges for India
4. Institutionalisation of engagements has begun only recently.
5. Central Asia has not been a strategic priority for India.
6. Indian strategy toward the region in the past has been subservient to its Afghanistan, China and Pakistan policies, and influenced by Russian and US designs.

China in Central Asia

In May 2023, China hosted **China-Central Asia Summit (C+C5) in Xi'an** to boost strategic cooperation with Central Asia on Belt and Road Initiative, Global Security Initiative, and Global Civilisation Initiative and efforts to end the war in Ukraine. During the summit, Xi Jinping reiterated that the security, sovereignty, independence, and territorial integrity of CARs must be upheld.

Probable Questions:

1. Discuss the prospects and challenges of India’s relationship with Central Asian Republics. How can India’s membership of SCO can boost Connect Central Asia policy?

2. Rejuvenating strategic convergence between India and Central Asia can provide a much-needed equilibrium in India's extended western neighbourhood. Discuss.

ASEAN

The Association of Southeast Asian Nations, or ASEAN, was established on 8 August 1967 in Bangkok, Thailand, with the signing of the ASEAN Declaration (Bangkok Declaration). Founding Members were Indonesia, Malaysia, Philippines, Singapore and Thailand.

Fundamental principles in mutual relations: Formulated through Treaty of Amity and Cooperation in Southeast Asia (TAC) of 1976:

1. Mutual respect for the independence, sovereignty, equality, territorial integrity, and national identity of all nations
2. The right of every State to lead its national existence free from external interference, subversion or coercion
3. Non-interference in the internal affairs of one another
4. Settlement of differences or disputes by peaceful manner
5. Renunciation of the threat or use of force; and
6. Effective cooperation among themselves

In 2003, ASEAN moved along the path of the European Union by agreeing to establish an ASEAN community comprising three pillars:

1. The ASEAN security community
2. The ASEAN economic community
3. The ASEAN socio-cultural community.

ASEAN Way: Refers to a methodology or approach to solving issues that respect Southeast Asia's cultural norms. Policymakers constantly utilise compromise, consensus, and consultation in the informal decision-making process. It prioritises a consensus-based, non-conflictual way of addressing problems.

Important ASEAN-led Forums

- **ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF):** Developed in 1993 to facilitate cooperation on political and security issues to contribute to regional confidence-building and preventive diplomacy.
- **ASEAN Plus Three:** Initiated in 1997 brings together ASEAN's ten members, China, Japan, and South Korea.
- **East Asia Summit (EAS):** First held in 2005. It seeks to promote security and prosperity in the region and is usually attended by the heads of state from ASEAN, Australia, China, India, Japan, New Zealand, Russia, South Korea, and the United States. ASEAN plays a central role as the agenda-setter.

Significance:

1. It is the 6th largest economy in the world and among the fastest growing markets.

2. It has Free-trade agreements (FTAs) with China, Japan, South Korea, India, Australia and New Zealand. Member of trade pacts like RCEP and CPTPP.
3. Key battlefield for contest between USA and China.
4. Lies at the heart of Indo-Pacific.
5. Has geopolitical hotspots like South China Sea and Strait of Malacca as a choke point.

Challenges:

1. Nations are divided between Pro-China and pro-USA. They have not been able to take a consensus position against Chinese adventurism in the region.
2. Recent events like exodus of Rohingyas has divided nations on religious and ethnic lines.
3. Lacks military capability to remain a relevant player in the emerging geopolitics.
4. New groupings like QUAD and AUKUS may reduce the significance of ASEAN.
5. China's island building and militarization of islands in the South China Sea.

India- ASEAN Relations

India ASEAN relationship has evolved from the 'Look East Policy' enunciated in early 1990s which led India to become a Sectoral Partner of ASEAN in 1992, a Dialogue Partner in 1996 and a Summit-level Partner in 2002. The relationship upgraded into Strategic Partnership in 2012. There are, in total, 30 Dialogue Mechanisms between India and ASEAN, cutting across various sectors.

Look East Policy has changed into a dynamic and action-oriented "Act East Policy" in 2014 during the 12th ASEAN-India Summit and 9th East Asia Summit.

Significance for India:

1. Central to ensuring China's peaceful rise and ensuring rule-based order in the Indo-Pacific.
2. Critical sea lanes of communication pass through the region.
3. Lies in India's primary area of interest (As per Maritime Security Strategy 2015).
4. India's 4th largest trading partner.
5. Critical to the success of Act East Policy and development & stability of India's Northeast
6. Important investment destination and a market for Indian exports.
7. ASEAN nations like Philippines, Vietnam and Malaysia are emerging as key markets for India's defence exports.
8. Important for India's energy security and food security.
9. Cultural and civilizational linkages.

Economic Cooperation:

India-ASEAN have signed FTA in goods, services and investment. ASEAN is India's fourth largest trading partner. India's trade with ASEAN stands at \$122.67 billion in 2023-24.

ASEAN accounts for approximately 18.28% of investment flows into India since 2000. The ASEAN-India Free Trade Area has been completed with the entering into force of the ASEAN-India Agreements on Trade in Service and Investments on 1 July 2015.

1. Major exports from India: Ships, boats, floating structures, mineral fuels, mineral oils and meat.
2. Major imports: telecom equipment, electrical machinery, mineral fuels, mineral oils and animal or vegetable fats and oils.

India and ASEAN are in talks to review the FTA in goods to increase more market access.

Security Cooperation:

1. Milan Naval exercise with many of the Southeast Asian nations.
2. ASEAN nations are part of India's HADR initiatives.
3. Engagement through multiple platforms like ARF, ADMM+ etc.
4. India has sold weapons to Philippines. Other nations like Vietnam and Malaysia are also interested.

Challenges:

1. ASEAN wants India to have a more prominent security role but India lacks requisite capacity.
2. Concerns about USA-China strategic rivalry in the region and fear of India getting dragged into it.
3. Delay on the part of India to sell defence platforms.

Beijing has been pressurising ASEAN members states to insert certain clauses in the Code to restrict Japan, India, the US and Australia as well as other nations from engaging in maritime security cooperation with the South East Asian states and exploring resources in the South China Sea.

Delhi Dialogue: India has an annual Track 1.5 event Delhi Dialogue, for discussing politico-security and economic issues between ASEAN and India. The 10th edition of Delhi Dialogue was hosted by the MEA on 19-20 July 2018 in New Delhi, with the theme, "Strengthening India-ASEAN Maritime Advantage".

Platforms for engaging with ASEAN Nations:

1. BIMSTEC and Mekong Ganga Cooperation
2. Asia-Europe Meeting (ASEM)
3. East Asia Summit (EAS)
4. ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF)
5. ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting + (ADMM+)
6. Expanded ASEAN Maritime Forum (EAMF).

Connectivity:

1. In 2013, India became the third dialogue partner of ASEAN to initiate an ASEAN Connectivity Coordinating Committee-India Meeting.
2. India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway
3. The Kaladan Multimodal Project,

4. At 18th India- ASEAN summit, India proposed a \$1 billion line of credit to promote physical and digital connectivity in ASEAN

A possible extension to India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway to Cambodia, Lao PDR and Vietnam is also under consideration.

Agriculture: Exchange of Farmers, ASEAN-India Fellowships for Higher Agricultural Education in India and ASEAN, Exchange of Agriculture Scientists, Empowerment of Women through Cooperatives, Training Course on Organic Certification for Fruits and Vegetables etc.

Science and Technology: Projects such as ASEAN-India S&T Digital Library, ASEAN-India Virtual Institute for Intellectual Property, ASEAN-India Collaborative Project on S&T for Combating Malaria, ASEAN-India Programme on Quality Systems in Manufacturing, ASEAN-India Collaborative R&D Project on Mariculture, Bio-mining and Bioremediation Technologies etc.

During Covid-19 pandemic, under QUAD, decision to supply 1 billion covid-19 vaccine to ASEAN nations by 2022.

Convergence:

1. Commitment to Rule-based World order, multipolarity and multilateralism.
2. ASEAN-centric vision of the Indo-Pacific.
3. Shared concern about great- power rivalry in the region.
4. China as a common geopolitical threat and need to ensure that China's rise remains peaceful.
5. Common desire to deepen economic engagements and diversify supply chain linkages.
6. Tackling traditional and non-traditional security threats and safety of sea Lanes of Communication.
7. Threat of climate change, rising sea level and extreme weather phenomena.

Divergences:

1. India's withdrawal from RCEP and talks about review of India-ASEAN FTA.
2. India- ASEAN trade is one-fifth of ASEAN-China trade.
3. Delay on the part of India to complete connectivity projects Asian trilateral Highway and Kaladan Multimodal Project.
4. India has been circumspect in its security commitments to the region.
5. There has been a delay in export of military platforms from India.

ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific

- ASEAN Outlook reinforces the ASEAN-centred regional architecture which is not aimed at creating new mechanisms or replacing existing ones.

- It intends to enhance ASEAN's Community building process and to strengthen and give new momentum for existing ASEAN-led mechanisms, including the East Asia Summit (EAS), the ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF) etc.
- It enumerates the four functional areas through which ASEAN believes collaboration can be tangibly advanced: 1. Maritime cooperation 2. Connectivity 3. Sustainable development 4. Economic and Other Possible Areas of Cooperation.

India's Vision for Indo-Pacific

In the **Shangri La Dialogue**, India's Indo-Pacific vision was explained by the Prime Minister:

- It stands for a free, open, inclusive region, which embraces all in a common pursuit of progress and prosperity. It includes all nations in this geography as also others beyond who have a stake in it.
- Southeast Asia is at its Centre and ASEAN central to its future.
- A common rules-based order for the region formed through dialogue. These rules and norms should be based on the consent of all, not on the power of the few.
- Rather than growing protectionism, India seeks for a level playing field for all. India stands for open and stable international trade regime.
- Connectivity is vital and India is doing its part, by itself and in partnership with others like Japan – in South Asia and Southeast Asia, in the Indian Ocean, Africa, West Asia and beyond.
- India's view can be summarized into five "S" in Hindi: Samman, Samvad, Shanti, Sahyog and Samriddhi.

China in ASEAN:

1. China has become largest trade partner of ASEAN, replacing EU. Bilateral trade is over \$500 billion.
2. They have upgraded their relationship to Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.
3. China aims to strengthen connectivity with ASEAN through Digital Silk Road and infrastructure projects like high speed rail project.
4. Chinese influence has resulted in division within ASEAN. Cambodia, Laos and Myanmar are Pro-China while Vietnam, Indonesia and Philippines have concerns with China.

Challenge:

1. Concerned about great power rivalry.
2. Due to territorial disputes in South China Sea, most nations see China as threat.
3. Fear of China weaponising trade, just as in case of Australia.
4. Concerns against BRI projects: In Laos, locals are complaining about involvement of Chinese labourers, Malaysia had cancelled many projects while Myanmar has scaled down the projects.
5. Due to lack of unanimity, ASEAN is unable to take a common position against Chinese coercion.
6. Capacity difference between ASEAN and China results in poor bargaining capacity of small ASEAN nations.

Probable Solution:

1. ASEAN is deepening engagements with USA. At the recent USA- ASEAN summit, both underscored the need to finalise and implement the South China Sea Code of Conduct (CoC).
2. ASEAN is looking at India as a potential market to wean off its dependence from China and a regional security provider.

USA-ASEAN Summit:

- Hosted by the USA.
- US-ASEAN joint vision statement reiterated the commitment of the partnership in addressing issues such as the COVID-19 recovery, economic connectivity, technological innovation, and climate change.
- Promoting maritime security and cooperation with importance of finalising and implementing the South China Sea Code of Conduct (CoC).
- ASEAN want a Code of Conduct to ensure peace and security in the disputed area and to uphold international law, and China wants to make sure that the dispute remains exclusively between ASEAN claimants and China, minimising the involvement of extra-regional powers in the disputed area.
- The European Union's Indo- Pacific strategy has underscored its commitment to a naval presence in Southeast Asia. With specific emphasis on the South China Sea dispute, it espouses the need to protect freedom of navigation in the region.

European Union

- The European Union is a group of 27 countries that operate as a cohesive economic and political block. It grew out of a desire to form a single European political entity to end centuries of warfare among European countries that culminated with World War II and decimated much of the continent.
- The EU has developed an internal single market through a standardized system of laws that apply in all member states in matters, where members have agreed to act as one. Through the Common Foreign and Security Policy, the union has developed a role in external relations and defence.
- In 2012, the EU was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize for advancing the causes of peace, reconciliation, democracy and human rights in Europe.

Achievements of EU:

1. It has ensured peace in the Europe.
2. Shining example of benefits of mutual cooperation across the sectors.
3. Made Europe a key pole in geopolitics.
4. It has made Europe a prominent economic and technological powerhouse.
5. Helped in driving Eastern European nations out of poverty and ensuring better governance.
6. A model of supranational authority that can be emulated.

Challenges:

1. Internal divisions on the basis of ideology and economic prosperity.
2. Demand for assertion of separate identity and sovereignty. E.g., Brexit.
3. Threats emerging from Russia and China.
4. Emergence of border fencing due to refugee crisis.
5. Military dependence on Europe has limited the geopolitical influence of European Union.
6. Covid-19 and resultant uncertainty has posed new set of challenges.
7. The ongoing Ukraine crisis has also led to divisions within the union.

Brexit: Brexit was the withdrawal of the United Kingdom from the European Union at 23:00 GMT on 31 January 2020. United Kingdom had been a member of European Union since 1973.

India-European Union Relations

- In 1962, India was the first developing country to establish diplomatic relations with European community.
- EU-India Cooperation Agreement 1994 provides the legal framework for EU-India relations. India and the EU have been strategic partners since 2004.
- In 2000, the first India-EU Summit took place. The relationship was upgraded into a 'Strategic Partnership' in 2004.
- In 2018, EU's strategy on India titled "A Partnership for Sustainable Modernization and Rules-based Global Order" was issued which views India as an emerging global power that plays a key role in the current multipolar world and a factor of stability in a complex region and calls for greater India-EU political, security and defence cooperation.

Significance of EU:

1. Second largest economy in nominal terms and third in purchasing power parity.
2. France is a P-5 member and Germany is an aspirant.
3. Technological leadership in defence manufacturing, renewable energy, nuclear energy, water conservation etc.
4. Major export market.
5. Significant voice at the UN, WTO, Climate change negotiations and global diplomacy.

Economic Relations:

1. The EU is India's largest trading partner as a bloc, with bilateral trade crossing \$124.36 billion. It is second largest destination for Indian exports.
2. EU is the biggest foreign investor in India, with €108.3.7 billion worth of investments by 2022.
3. An investment facilitation mechanism for EU investments in India has been established in 2017. This has renewed focus on facilitating ease of doing business norms for EU investors in India.

4. Negotiations for a broad-based Bilateral Trade and Investment Agreement (BTIA) was held between 2007–2013 but negotiations were suspended after multiple impasses. The negotiations were restarted in June 2022.

Broad Based Trade and Investment Agreement (BTIA)

It is being negotiated since 2007. The negotiations have been stalled since 2013. Both sides have major differences on crucial issues such as-

- **EU's demands:** significant duty cuts in automobiles, tax reduction on wines, spirits etc, a strong intellectual property regime, relaxation in India's data localisation norms, protection to all its items with Geographical Indication etc.
- **India's demands:** 'Data secure' status (important for India's IT sector); Ease norms on temporary movement of skilled workers, relaxation of Sanitary and Phytosanitary (SPS) and Technical Barriers to Trade (TBT) norms etc.

At the India-EU virtual summit in 2021, Both India and EU have agreed to engage for restarting the stalled BTIA. The negotiations have started. The aim is to strike the deal by 2023.

As per June 2020 study by the European Parliamentary Research Service, FTA can increase exports from the EU to India by about 52% to 56%, while imports from India would rise between 33% and 35%.

Defence Cooperation:

Though India does not have defence cooperation with European Union, it does have deep relationships with individual nations like France, Germany and Italy. After Ukraine crisis, European nations have gone for increasing their defence expenditure with Germany increasing it by more than \$100 billion and taking it above 2% of GDP. This provides opportunity for defence to be a new area of cooperation between India and European Union.

- First ever India eve security and defence consultations were held in Brussels in June 2022.
- Both sides discussed about increasing maritime security cooperation and prospect of Co-development and Co-production of defence equipments.

Maritime Cooperation:

- Both India and the EU have stressed on the idea of freedom of navigation, maritime piracy, and adherence to United Nation Conventions on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) and the development of the blue economy and maritime infrastructure.
- Both have identified the Indo-Pacific as the new avenue for maritime cooperation.
- In January 2021, India and the EU hosted the first Maritime security dialogue in a virtual format. It has become a regular event.

Climate Change:

- Since 2016, the EU and India have together pursued a Clean Energy and Climate Partnership (CECP), which focuses on developing cooperation in clean energy and the

implementation of the Paris Agreement, including in the area of energy efficiency, renewable energy, smart grids, storage, sustainable finance, and climate mitigation and adaptation.

- The International Solar Alliance, founded by France and India, has a target to mobilise more than US \$1 trillion by 2030, apart from bringing down the overall cost of solar energy installations.
- In March 2021, the EU became a member of the **Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure**, which was also co-founded by India.
- The EU has also invested in numerous programmes such as India-EU water partnership, solar park programme, and Facilitating Offshore Wind in India (FOWIND). One of the major investments was the signing of the 200 million EUR loan agreement between the EIB and the Indian Renewable Energy Development Agency.

Connectivity:

- During 2021 virtual summit, the two sides launched a “**connectivity partnership**” to pursue sustainable joint projects in other countries, particularly those in Africa, Central Asia and the Indo-Pacific region.
- The India-European Union (EU) Connectivity Partnership will be a vital component of the EU’s Global Gateway initiative that aims to create ‘links and not dependencies’ through investments in quality infrastructure in order to connect goods, services, institutions, banks, businesses and people across the world.
- Both are cooperation on India-Middle-East-Europe Corridor.

Global Gateway Initiative: For the European Union (EU), China is both a crucial trading partner, and an economic competitor and systemic rival. Aiming to align with third countries for mutual benefit to offset China’s influence, the EU, on 15 September 2021, launched its Global Gateway initiative. A connectivity initiative designed to counter China’s Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). It has dedicating €300 billion for Global Gateway investments between 2021 and 2027.

Energy Cooperation: EU – India Clean Energy and Climate Partnership.

Research and Development: India, participates in international ITER fusion project to demonstrate the scientific viability of fusion as a future sustainable energy source.

Environment and Water: The EU and India also cooperate closely on the Indian Clean Ganga initiative.

ICT Cooperation: The EU and India aim to link the ‘Digital Single Market’ with the ‘Digital India’. Apart from these “Start-up Europe India Network” initiative and EU-India Cyber Security Dialogue deserves special mention.

Migration and mobility: The EU-India Common Agenda on Migration and Mobility (CMM) is a fundamental cooperation agreement between India and EU.

Convergences:

1. Similar type of multicultural, multi-ethnic and multi-religious societies.
2. Commitment to democracy, human rights and Rule of law.

3. Shared vision of a multipolar world order and strengthening of United Nations.
4. Shared threat of China and convergence on rule-based order in the Indo-Pacific.
5. Economic and technological complementarities.
6. Common threat of terrorism, radicalisation and stake in stabilising Afghanistan.

Divergences:

1. BTIA negotiations have not yet been completed.
2. Disagreements over India's IPR regime and Investor-State Dispute Settlement mechanism.
3. Disagreements over Human Rights issues in India, that India considers as internal matter.
4. EU expressed its displeasure over change in status of Jammu and Kashmir.
5. On Ukraine crisis, many EU nations have criticised India's stance.
6. On climate change, demands for greater commitment from India.

India- EU on China:

Convergence:

1. Shared threat about China and instability in the Indo-Pacific.
2. EU considers China as a systemic threat and a challenge for European unity and solidarity.
3. Both are opposed to China's revisionism and debt-trap diplomacy.

Divergence:

1. EU looks at China more as a market and less as a threat.
2. Both you and China aim to cooperate in tackling climate change.
3. EU Looks at Russia as a bigger threat compared to China

Indo-Pacific:

1. Both India and EU agree on Free, Open, Peaceful and rule-based order in the Indo-Pacific.
2. ASEAN's centrality is common to the EU's and India's respective Indo-Pacific commercial connectivity agendas.
3. The new German government considers the Indo-Pacific a priority.
4. It has deployed naval ships on patrol in the Indo-Pacific region and its Air Force would be participating in pitch black exercise in Australia.
5. In 2021, French naval ships and submarines were present in the East Asia. France sees itself as a resident power in the region, and was the first EU country to develop an Indo-Pacific strategy.

Latin America

Latin America is the portion of the Americas comprising countries and regions where Romance languages—languages that derived from Latin—such as Spanish, Portuguese, and French are predominantly spoken. The term was originally used to refer to places in the Americas that were ruled under the Spanish, Portuguese, and French empires.

India- Latin America Relations

Mexico was the first Latin American country to recognize India after its independence in 1947.

Importance of Latin America:

1. The region is very important for India in order to achieve its global ambitions like membership of the UNSC, the NSG and at various other negotiations like climate change, terrorism, trade, etc
2. India is cooperating with Brazil at platforms like BRICS, IBSA which has provided an alternative platform for developing countries
3. Having energy rich nations like Brazil, Mexico, Venezuela; region is key to India's energy security.
4. Latin America has three G20 economies, i.e., Brazil, Mexico, and Argentina. Thus, making it a preferable market for Indian businesses.
5. Mineral rich region with strategic minerals like lithium, cobalt, copper etc.
6. Food security- large arable areas in Brazil, Argentina etc.

Economic Relations:

- The annual India-Latin America trade had reached \$50 billion in 2022-23, with a target to double it to \$100 billion by 2027.
- Latin America is a key market for Indian cars (28%), Motor cycles (22%), pharmaceuticals and IT services.
- India imports edible oils and sugar from Brazil and Argentina; copper and precious metals from Chile and Peru; wood from Ecuador, etc. In turn India exports diesel, textiles and manufactured products.
- India has promoted a strategic partnership with Brazil; a privileged partnership with Mexico. India has PTA with MERCOSUR. **Mercosur** is a South American Trade Bloc. Its full members are Argentina, Brazil, Paraguay, and Uruguay.
- India is looking at exploring the potential of region for defence exports.

Indian investment in Latin American hydrocarbons, pharma, automobiles, agro-processing, engineering, textiles, chemicals, electronics is estimated around \$20 billion

Energy Security: India now imports 20% of its crude oil from Brazil, Columbia, Mexico and Venezuela. Latin America is also an important partner in the India led International Solar Alliance.

Food Security: Latin America can also contribute towards food security. The region is five times the size of India and has only half the population. India imports soy oil from Argentina and Brazil and more than 20% of its edible oil from the region. Surplus arable land with Latin America can be key to India's food security.

Cheaper imports: Latin America is also very rich in minerals such as copper, lithium, iron ore, gold and silver, and could give India an opportunity to increase investments for their extraction as well as for their import at cheaper rates.

India is trying to acquire cobalt and lithium mines in Argentina, Bolivia and Chile.

Challenges:

1. Geographical distance
2. Language barrier
3. India lacks membership of key institutions like Inter-American Development Bank. However, India has PTA with Mercosur.
4. India lacks diplomatic presence and engagement with whole nations. Its engagement is limited to key nations like Mexico, Brazil and Argentina.

Suggestions:

1. Ensuring diplomatic presence in all Latin American nations.
2. High level diplomatic engagements with all Latin American nations, apart from Mexico, Brazil and Argentina.
3. Government should complement the engagement by private sector in the region.
4. Going for joint development of lithium mines in lithium triangle nations. This can be key to domestic battery manufacturing and achieving green mobility targets.